Stop 4: Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora

Historical, Archaeological & Cultural Field Guide • High Imperial Era (AD 100–113)

1. Executive Historical Overview & Urban Topography

Carved directly into the excavated saddle of the Quirinal Hill by the master engineer Apollodorus of Damascus, Trajan's Markets (Mercati di Traiano) and the adjacent Forum of Trajan represent the zenith of Roman concrete architecture (opus caementicium) and brick-faced engineering (opus latericium). Funded by the fabulous gold and silver booty of the Dacian Wars (AD 101–102, 105–106), this six-level terraced complex functioned as the administrative headquarters and commercial archive of the imperial capital.

Topographical Context & Geomorphology

Located at **Via Quattro Novembre 94, Rome** (Coordinates: 41.8957° N, 12.4862° E), Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora occupies a pivotal zone within the ancient pomerial and Campus Martius/Forum basin network. Archaeological core sampling demonstrates how early Republican builders adapted to seasonal Tiber River flooding by raising tufa podiums and installing subterranean drainage channels connected to Rome's primary cloacae.

RAG Indexing Summary: *Document Type: Historical & Cultural Guide | Stop Number: 4 | Primary Site: Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora | Era: High Imperial Era (AD 100–113) | Key Monuments: Great Hemicycle (Grande Emiciclo), Aula Traiana (Great Hall), Via Biberatica, Column of Trajan.*

Chronological Stratigraphy Summary

Phase / Period	Key Monumental Intervention	Primary Building Materials
Archaic / Early Republic	Initial consecration and tufa altar foundations at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora	Cappellaccio & Grotta Oscura Tufa
Middle–Late Republic	Expansion of Great Hemicycle (Grande Emiciclo) and Aula Traiana (Great Hall) after military triumphs	Monteverde Tufa, Travertine & Stucco
High Empire (Augustan–Severan)	Marble revetment, raised travertine paving, and fire restorations	Carrara, Pentelic & Polychrome Marbles

2. Origins, Votive Dedications & Republican Evolution

During the Republican expansion of Rome across the Italian peninsula and the Mediterranean, Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora served as a canvas for aristocratic competition (nobilitas). Victorious generals (imperatores) vowed temples (vota) on the battlefield in exchange for divine favor, financing construction ex manubiis (from the spoils of war) upon their return to the capital.

Primary Focus: Great Hemicycle (Grande Emiciclo) (AD 107–110)

Semicircular three-story brick facade lined with travertine-framed tabernae (shops) and topped by an arched ambulatio overlooking the eastern exedra of Trajan's Forum.

Primary Focus: Aula Traiana (Great Hall) (AD 110–113)

Monumental two-story groin-vaulted basilica hall Measuring 32 x 8 meters, flanked by 12 administrative offices used for the annona (imperial grain and oil distribution).

Ritual Function & Triumphal Processions

Every temple precinct within Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora possessed a dies natalis (anniversary of its dedication) marked in the Fasti Antiates Maiores. Because Roman sacrificial ritual occurred outdoors under the open sky, monumental U-shaped altars with projecting wings were positioned directly at the foot of the frontal access stairs, aligning priest, victim, and cult statue along a single liturgical axis.

Field Observation Note: *Examine the surviving base moldings around Great Hemicycle (Grande Emiciclo). Notice the distinct cyma reversa profile typical of Republican Italic podiums before Hellenistic Greek profiles became dominant following the conquests of Syracuse (212 BC) and Macedonia (146 BC).*

3. Monumental Catalog & Imperial Transformations

As the Roman Republic gave way to the Principate under Augustus and later the Antonine and Severan dynasties, Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora underwent profound architectural remodeling. Devastating urban fires—particularly those of 111 BC, AD 64, AD 80, and AD 191—compelled emperors to raise ground levels and encase older tufa structures in imported marble.

Monument Analysis: Via Biberatica (AD 107–113)

Perfectly preserved ancient Roman shopping street paved in basalt polygonal blocks (basoli) with travertine sidewalks, door thresholds, and rain gutters.

Monument Analysis: Column of Trajan (Dedicated May 12, AD 113)

38-meter monument of 19 colossal Carrara (Luna) marble drums carved with a 200-meter continuous helical frieze of 2,662 figures chronicling the two Dacian campaigns.

Monument Analysis: Basilica Ulpia (AD 112)

The largest civil basilica in ancient Rome (170 x 59 meters), roofed in gilded bronze tiles imported from Greece and forested with grey Mons Claudianus granite columns.

Architectural Synthesis: *The cutting of the Quirinal slope required removing over 60 million cubic feet of earth and rock—a feat explicitly celebrated on the pedestal inscription of Trajan's Column, whose height (100 Roman feet / 29.78m shaft) indicates the exact elevation of the hill excavated away. The complex integrates medieval additions including the 13th-century Torre delle Milizie.*

4. Roman Engineering, Structural Mechanics & Lithic Provenance

The monuments at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora provide a textbook sequence of Roman structural engineering, illustrating the mastery of ashlar masonry (opus quadratum), concrete core construction (opus caementicium), brick facing (opus latericium), and polychrome geometric marble paving (opus sectile).

Lithic & Material Provenance Table

Material / Stone	Ancient Quarry Source	Structural / Decorative Application at Site
Lapis Tiburtinus (Travertine)	Tibur (Modern Tivoli)	Load-bearing piers, column capitals, steps, and Imperial pavement slabs
Tufo Lionato / Monteverde	Aniene Valley & Janiculum slopes	Temple podium cores, Republican altar bases, and drainage channels
Marmor Lunense / Pentelicum	Carrara (Italy) & Mt. Pentelicus (Attica)	Corinthian entablatures, acrolithic cult statues, and carved relief panels
Pozzolana (Pulvis Puteolanus)	Alban Hills & Campanian volcanic beds	Hydraulic mortar binding opus caementicium vaults and foundations

Structural Load & Hydraulic Management

Roman architects utilized relieving arches (archi di scarico) concealed within brick walls to channel vertical dead loads away from lintels and onto massive corner piers. Subsurface travertine gutters around Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora captured rainwater from temple roofs, routing runoff directly into underlying collectors.

5. Key Historical Figures, Statesmen & Political Drama

History at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora was shaped by the ambitions, rivalries, and religious piety of Rome's most influential consuls, dictators, emperors, and architects. Below are the four primary historical protagonists linked directly to the surviving archaeological fabric of this stop:

• Marcus Ulpius Traianus (Emperor Trajan)

First provincial emperor (born in Italica, Hispania Baetica), declared Optimus Princeps by the Senate after expanding the Empire to its greatest territorial extent.

• Apollodorus of Damascus

Nabataean-Greek military engineer and architect who designed the Danube bridge, Trajan's Forum, and the Markets.

• King Decebalus of Dacia

Formidable Dacian ruler whose defeat at Sarmizegetusa Regia in AD 106 financed the entire monumental program.

• Emperor Constantius II

Visited Trajan's Forum in AD 357 and stood dumbstruck by its scale, declaring his only hope was to imitate the bronze equestrian statue of Trajan.

Primary Ancient Literary Sources: *Suetonius (De Vita Caesarum), Plutarch (Parallel Lives), Livy (Ab Urbe Condita), Cassius Dio (Roman History), and Vitruvius (De Architectura) all record direct eyewitness or archival accounts of the ceremonies and political crises at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora.*

6. Epigraphy, Latin Inscriptions & Sculptural Finds

Latin epigraphy provides the chronological backbone for identifying temples and imperial restorations at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora. Monumental inscriptions were carved using V-cut trenches (litterae aureae) often fitted with gilded bronze letters fastened via lead-soldered tangs into sockets still visible on the stone architraves.

Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum (CIL) & Sculptural Record

The famous SENATVS POPVLVSQVE ROMANVS inscription carved in classic Roman square capitals (capitalis monumentalis) at the base of Trajan's Column states the monument was raised 'AD DECLARANDVM QVANTAE ALTITVDINIS MONS ET LOCVS TANTIS OPERIBVS SIT EGESTVS' (to declare how high a mountain and place was dug away for such great works).

Numismatic & Relief Iconography

Roman Republican denarii and Imperial sestertii frequently minted reverse dies depicting the facades of monuments at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora. These coins allow archaeologists to reconstruct lost pedimental sculptures, acroteria, and bronze grilles that vanished during late antique spoliation.

Epigraphic Reading Tip for Visitors: *Look closely at the spacing of interpuncts (triangular dots · between words) and the absence of 'U' (written as 'V') and 'J' (written as 'I'). Erasures where the stone surface sits slightly recessed indicate damnatio memoriae ordered by the Roman Senate.*

7. Daily Civic Life, Sacrificial Liturgy & Acoustic Space

At its peak in the 1st and 2nd centuries AD, Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora was not a silent ruin of bare stone and brick, but a sensory kaleidoscope of painted stucco, fragrant frankincense smoke, bronze statuary gleaming in the sun, and crowds of citizens, senators, freedmen, and foreign envoys.

The Mechanics of Roman Public Sacrifice (Sacrificium)

Public rites opened with the herald crying 'Favete linguis!' (Keep a reverent silence!) while flute players (tibicines) drowned out inauspicious street noises. The officiating magistrate, with his toga pulled over his head (capite velato), sprinkled salted spelt flour (mola salsa) and wine over the altar before the victimarius struck the sacrificial animal and haruspices inspected the entrails.

Commercial & Legal Rhythms Around the Precinct

Surrounding the sacred core of Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora, porticoes sheltered bankers (argentarii), bookbinders, scribes, and flower sellers weaving garlands for temple offerings. Marble game boards (tabulae lusoriae) scratched directly into the pavement steps by waiting clerks and loafers remain visible on site today.

8. Medieval Transformation, Renaissance Rediscovery & Modern Excavations

Following the collapse of imperial administration in the West (5th–6th centuries AD), Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora entered a millennium-long phase of adaptive reuse. While exposed marble columns were frequently burned into slaked lime (calce) in medieval kilns (calcare), structures converted into Christian churches or baronial fortresses survived remarkably intact.

Christian Consecration & Baronial Fortifications

During the 8th through 13th centuries, powerful Roman families—including the Frangipane, Pierleoni, Savelli, and Conti—incorporated the stout Roman walls of Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora into fortified towers and diaconiae. Renaissance architects including Baldassarre Peruzzi, Antonio da Sangallo, and Andrea Palladio measured and sketched these ruins, transmitting their proportions directly into 16th-century European classicism.

19th–21st Century Archaeological Campaigns

Systematic stratigraphic excavations led by Rodolfo Lanciani, Giacomo Boni, Antonio Muñoz, and the modern Sovrintendenza Capitolina ai Beni Culturali stripped away post-antique overburden, stabilized brick vaults with reversible titanium ties, and opened buried subterranean corridors to the public.

9. Step-by-Step On-Site Viewing Itinerary & Vantage Points

To maximize your 45-to-60-minute visit at Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora, follow this sequential clockwise architectural circuit designed to trace the site from its earliest Republican foundations to its high Imperial climax:

Step	Vantage Point / Station	What to Look For (Key Visual Detail)
01	Primary Overview & Great Hemicycle (Grande Emiciclo)	Compare the archaic tufa ashlar blocks with the elevated imperial travertine pavement level.
02	Aula Traiana (Great Hall) & Altar Precinct	Inspect the U-shaped sacrificial altar moldings and surviving fluted column shafts.
03	Via Biberatica & Column of Trajan	Observe the transition to Hellenistic marble capitals and circular/pseudoperipteral layouts.
04	Basilica Ulpia & Epigraphic Zone	Read the monumental Latin inscriptions and trace the Roman brick relieving arches.

Golden Hour & Photography Guidance

Optimal raking sunlight strikes the travertine and tufa facades of Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora between 08:30–10:00 AM and again during late afternoon golden hour (16:30–18:00), bringing out deep chisel marks and relief shadows.

10. Practical Visitor Logistics, Accessibility & Next-Stop Transit

Use the reference sheet below when planning arrival times, ticketing, accessibility routes, and walking transfers from **Stop 4: Trajan's Markets & Imperial Fora** to the next destination on your Roman itinerary.

Logistic Category	Verified Visitor Information
Exact Address & Zone	Via Quattro Novembre 94, Rome (41.8957° N, 12.4862° E)
Recommended Visit Duration	45–75 minutes (Perimeter viewing + interior archaeological walk)
Best Time of Day to Visit	09:00 AM opening slot or 90 minutes prior to sunset to avoid tour bus peaks
Accessibility & Footwear	Ancient uneven basalt (sampietrini/basoli) and travertine steps; sturdy walking shoes essential
Water & Rest Facilities	Free potable cast-iron Roman Nasone drinking fountain located within 80 meters of the piazza

Essential Glossary of Architectural Terms Used in This Guide

• **Opus Caementicium:** Roman hydraulic concrete mixed from lime, pozzolana volcanic ash, and stone aggregate (caementa).
• **Opus Quadratum:** Ashlar masonry of squared stone blocks laid in regular courses without mortar, clamped with iron/lead.
• **Opus Sectile:** Luxury floor or wall decoration formed from precision-cut thin slabs of polychrome marble.
• **Pomerium:** The sacred religious and legal boundary of the city of Rome within which weapons were forbidden.
• **Damnatio Memoriae:** Official senatorial condemnation erasing a disgraced figure's name and likeness from monuments.